

THE DEVELOPMENT OF THE HEBREW WAYYIQTOL ('WAW CONSECUTIVE') VERBAL FORM IN LIGHT OF GREEK AND LATIN TRANSCRIPTIONS OF HEBREW

Benjamin Kantor

1.0. INTRODUCTION

Hebrew is counted among the few languages of the world that have a specific 'sequential' past tense verbal form. What is particularly unique about the morphology of this Hebrew verbal form, however, is that it appears to be constructed from the conjunction *waw* (ו־ /v-/ 'and.CONJ') and a verb in the *prefix conjugation* (henceforth referred to as the '*yiqtol*' form), which is elsewhere used for non-past semantics (e.g., future, jussive). What is more, the conjunction *waw* is normally connected to this 'sequential' verbal form by means of gemination, a feature occurring in no other context following the conjunction *waw*. This verbal form has come to be known as either the '*waw* consecutive', or, as a more neutral term mirroring the morphological shape of the verb, the *wayyiqtol* form (Table 1):

Table 1

<i>waw</i>	<i>yiqtol</i>	<i>waw</i> + <i>yiqtol</i>	<i>wayyiqtol</i>
וְ	יִכְתֹּב	וְיִכְתֹּב	וְיִכְתֹּב
/v-/	/ji-χto:v/	/v-ji-χto:v/	/vaj-ji-χto:v/
[va-]	[ji-χ ^h o:ov]	[vi-ji-χ ^h o:ov]	[vaj-ji-χ ^h o:ov]
and.CONJ	3MS-write.YIQTOL	CONJ-3MS-write.YIQTOL	CONJ-3MS-write.(WAY)YIQTOL
‘and’	‘he will write; let him write!’	‘and let him write!’	‘and he wrote!’

The questions and issues surrounding the *wayyiqtol* form are primarily concerned with the form’s history and morphology. From a historical perspective, the questions regarding the *wayyiqtol* form relate to its grammatical origins and development within Biblical Hebrew. From a morphological perspective, the questions regarding the *wayyiqtol* form relate to the status of the conjunction *waw* as a component of the form, the presence of a full vowel after the conjunction *waw*, and the morphological derivation of the gemination in the following consonant.¹ Though neither of these topics can be addressed without addressing the other, at least in cursory fashion, the focus of this paper will be on the latter.

In particular, this paper will analyse all attestations of the *wayyiqtol* form in ancient Greek and Latin transcriptions of Biblical Hebrew in order to determine *when*, *why*, and *how* the conjunction *waw* in the *wayyiqtol* form came to be realised distinctly from the realisation of the conjunction *waw* elsewhere, with respect to both its vocalisation with *pataḥ* (instead of *shewa*) and the doubling of the following consonant. After a brief review of

¹ For an introduction to the issues, see Smith (1991, 1–15).

scholarship (§§2.0–4.0), the relevant data from the transcriptions will be presented and analysed (§5.0). Based on the findings, a plausible diachronic reconstruction will be suggested (§6.0). The paper will conclude by outlining the implications that such a reconstruction has for understanding the development of the Biblical Hebrew reading tradition(s) in the Second Temple period more broadly.

2.0. REVIEW OF SCHOLARSHIP: GRAMMATICAL DEVELOPMENT

Though not the focus of this paper—focused, as it is, on the morphological development of the form, rather than its grammatical origins—it behoves us to briefly rehearse the generally accepted view of how this ‘sequential’ past tense form developed from a grammatical perspective before more extensively detailing the various theories regarding the form’s morphology. According to most researchers, Proto-Central Semitic had both a long **yaqtulu* verb form, essentially used for indicative non-past semantics, and a short **yaqtul* verb form, used for both indicative past (preterite) and volitive meanings (jussive). These forms eventually fell together in Hebrew (in most paradigms) and both came to be vocalised as *yiqtol*.² Syntactically, the short/preterite *yiqtol* form (< **yaqtul*) gradually came to be replaced by *qatal* (< **qatala*) as the more common regular past-tense verb. It was only following

² This identity applies only to strong roots. Note that a number of weak roots (e.g., II-w/y, III-w/y) and the *hif’il* stem still exhibit two distinct forms, one ‘long’ (< **yaqtulu*) and one ‘short’ (< **yaqtul*).